

// • August 2026

Examine the people who want power.

A serious proposal for examining candidates for public office in India — why the current filter selects for exactly the wrong things, what the papers would actually contain, ministry by ministry, what it would cost, and the strongest case against the whole idea.

ballot-ink

ashoka brass

the diagnosis

the proposal

the house

Raghav • 12,700 words • twelve figures • everything I made up is labelled



// start here

Before you start

This is a thought experiment I have been arguing with myself about for a while, and I finally sat down and did the numbers.

The argument is simple and I think it is close to unanswerable: **India runs the hardest entrance examination on earth for the person who administers a district, and no examination at all for the person who runs the ministry that district reports into.** The Collector sits three papers, an interview board and a medical. The Minister sits nothing. That is not a quirk. That is the central design flaw, and almost everything that is wrong downstream falls out of it.

What follows is a full proposal, with syllabi, with weightings, with a cost model, and with a transition plan. I have written it the way I would want to read it, which means I have not hedged, and I have not padded it with the usual noises about how complicated everything is. Everything is complicated. That is not an argument for doing nothing.

Two honesty notes before we start.

THIS IS MY OPINION, NOT A POLICY PAPER

I am not a constitutional lawyer, a psychometrician or an election administrator. Every number in here is sourced and every number I made up myself is labelled as mine. The design choices are arguments, not conclusions - I have tried to make them concrete enough that you can disagree with a specific thing rather than a general vibe.

I HAVE PUT THE BEST CASE AGAINST ME IN THE BACK

Chapter 16 is a full-strength steelman written without pulling punches. If you only read one chapter of the second half, read that one. If the argument in this report cannot survive it, the argument does not deserve to survive.

PART I

What is actually broken

Six things, all of them measurable, none of them disputed by anybody who has looked.

01

// the vacancy

The job with no job description

Here is a thing that sounds like a joke and is not.

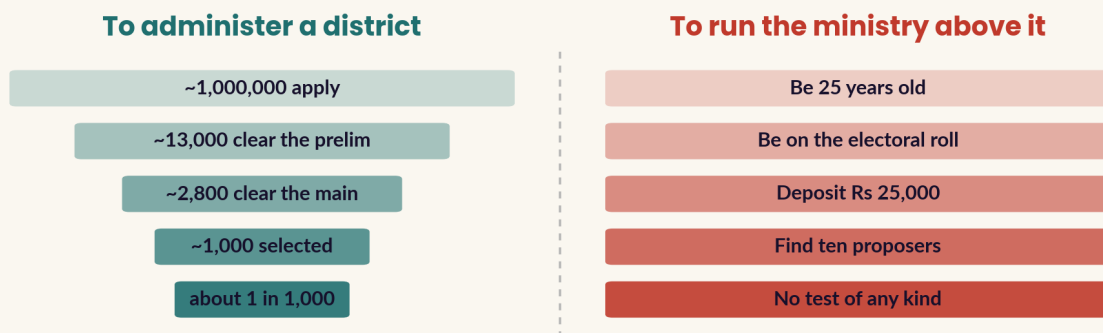
To become an Indian Administrative Service officer, you sit a preliminary examination, a main examination of nine papers totalling around 1,750 marks, and a personality test before a board. Roughly a million people register. Around a thousand are selected. The selection ratio is about one in a thousand, and the people who clear it have typically spent between two and five years preparing full time.

That officer will, within a decade or so, be running a district of two or three million people. And they will report, up the chain, to a Minister whose qualifications for the post are, in full: Indian citizen, at least twenty-five years old, name on an electoral roll somewhere in the country, ten proposers, and a security deposit of twenty-five thousand rupees.

// the asymmetry

We test the clerk. We do not test the boss.

The Union Public Service Commission filters roughly one applicant in a thousand to run a district. Their minister needs a birth certificate and a deposit.



Sources: UPSC Civil Services Examination annual reports (applicant and vacancy figures approximate and vary by year); Representation of the People Act, 1951, s.33 and s.34; Constitution of India, Art. 84.

The two funnels, drawn to the same scale. The left one is the filter for the person who implements. The right one is the filter for the person who decides.

That is the entire specification. There is no requirement that a Finance Minister be able to read a balance sheet. There is no requirement that a Health Minister know what a confidence interval is. There is no requirement that a Law Minister have opened the Constitution. There is not even a requirement of literacy at the Union level - the qualification tests that exist in Indian law are at the panchayat level in a handful of states, not in Parliament.

We built an examination state to staff the machine, and left the steering wheel unattended.

I want to be precise about what I am objecting to, because this argument gets caricatured immediately. I am not objecting to ordinary people holding power. I am objecting to the specific claim, which nobody actually defends out loud but everybody's behaviour assumes, that **being popular is evidence of being competent**. Those are two different variables. We measure one of them obsessively, every five years, at enormous expense. We have never once measured the other.

The counterfactual nobody runs

Defenders of the current arrangement usually say some version of: the minister sets direction, the bureaucracy supplies expertise, and the whole point of democratic control is that the amateur commands the professional.

I actually accept the second half of that. Civilian control of expertise is not negotiable and I will defend it later against people who want to abolish it. What I do not accept is that "sets direction" is a task requiring no knowledge. Setting direction on a power sector transition requires knowing what a levelised cost of energy is. Setting direction on a health system requires knowing the difference between prevalence and incidence. Setting direction on a fiscal package requires knowing what a fiscal multiplier is and roughly what its plausible range might be.

A minister who does not know these things does not "set direction". A minister who does not know these things gets handed a file with three options, is told which one the department prefers, signs it, and then goes out and defends a decision they did not make and cannot explain. Everybody in Delhi knows this happens. Nobody will say it with a name attached.

02

// the incentive

The wannability premium

If you want to understand a system, look at what it rewards.

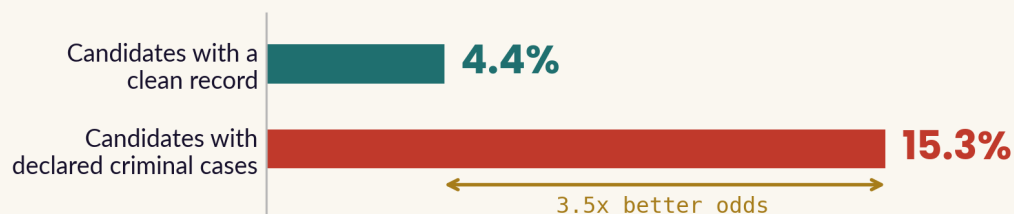
In the 2024 general election, a candidate contesting with a clean record had roughly a 4.4 per cent chance of winning their seat. A candidate contesting with declared criminal cases against them had a 15.3 per cent chance. Not a slightly better chance.

Three and a half times the chance.

// the incentive

Crime is not a liability at the ballot. It is an asset.

Probability of winning a Lok Sabha seat in 2024, by declared criminal background.



Source: Association for Democratic Reforms, analysis of 2024 Lok Sabha winning candidates.

Association for Democratic Reforms analysis of 2024 winning candidates. These are cases the candidates declared about themselves, in sworn affidavits, under penalty of perjury.

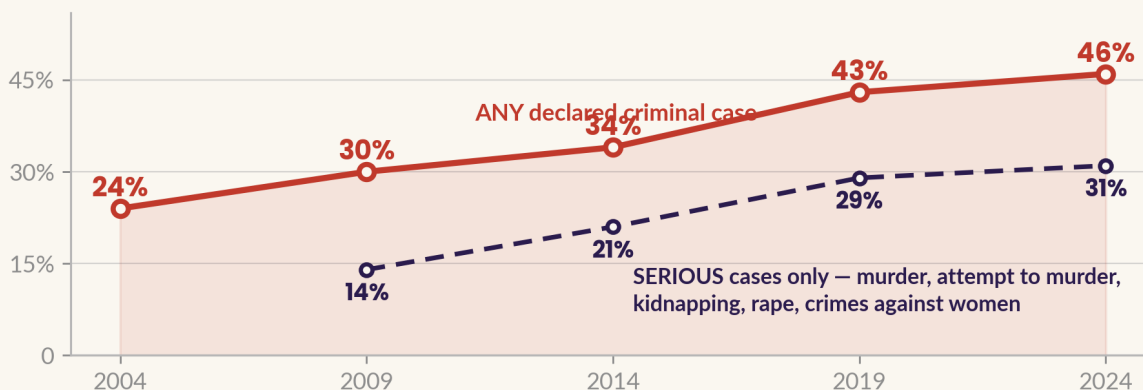
Sit with that number for a second, because it is doing more work than any other statistic in this report. It means that a rational party strategist, optimising purely for seats, should prefer the candidate with the police record. Not tolerate. Prefer. The record is not a cost they absorb; it is part of the asset they are buying - the local muscle, the settlement network, the ability to make a problem go away for a voter in a system where the formal state cannot.

And so the composition of the House moves in exactly the direction you would predict.

// twenty years

The filter has been running backwards.

Share of elected Lok Sabha MPs with criminal cases declared in their own sworn affidavits.



Source: ADR analyses of Lok Sabha winning candidates, 2004-2024. 2024: 251 of 543 MPs; 170 with serious charges.

Twenty years, one direction. The dashed line is the subset of cases involving murder, attempt to murder, kidnapping, rape and crimes against women.

In 2004, 24 per cent of elected MPs had criminal cases declared against them. In 2024, 46 per cent did - 251 of 543. The number of MPs with declared criminal cases has risen 55 per cent since 2009. And the serious end has grown faster than the total: 170 of the current House, 31 per cent, face charges of the murder-and-worse variety.

THE OBVIOUS OBJECTION, ANSWERED

"Cases are filed against politicians for political reasons." Yes. Some are. That is exactly why my proposal does not disqualify anybody for having a case filed against them, and why Gate 1 uses the Law Commission's standard - a charge FRAMED by a court for an offence carrying a serious sentence - rather than an FIR, which anybody can procure. A framed charge means a judge has looked at the material and found a case to answer. If we cannot use that as a threshold, we cannot use anything, and the criminal law means nothing.

Why this is not a morality complaint

I am not making the argument that criminals are bad people and should be kept away from nice institutions. I am making a structural argument.

A candidate whose electoral value derives partly from coercive capacity has, on entering office, an asset that appreciates. The office multiplies the coercion. The coercion protects the office. That is a closed loop, and a closed loop with positive feedback is not a moral failing, it is an engineering failure. You do not fix an engineering failure by asking the components to be nicer.

03

// the arithmetic

Where the money comes from

This is the chapter where I get genuinely angry, and I have tried to keep the anger in the prose and out of the numbers.

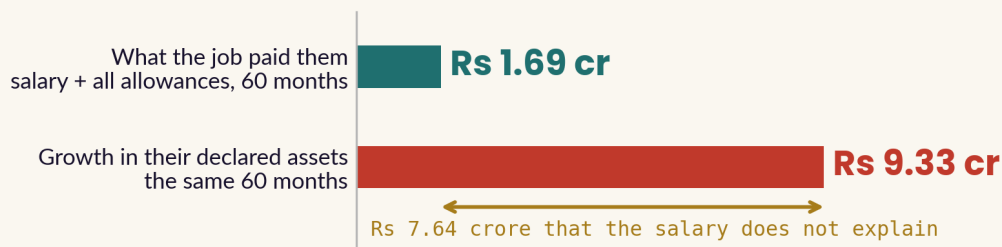
An Indian Member of Parliament is paid, after the 2025 revision, a salary of Rs 1.24 lakh a month, a constituency allowance of Rs 87,000 and an office expense allowance of Rs 75,000. Call it Rs 2.81 lakh a month, all in. Over a five-year term that is Rs 1.69 crore, gross, before a single rupee of tax or a single rupee of living expense.

Now here is what happened to the declared assets of the 324 sitting MPs who contested again in 2024. Average assets in 2019: Rs 21.55 crore. Average assets in 2024: Rs 30.88 crore. An average increase of **Rs 9.33 crore per MP**, over the same sixty months.

// the arithmetic

Five years on the job. Rs 1.69 crore earned. Rs 9.33 crore added.

Average across the 324 sitting MPs who contested again in 2024. Pay is calculated at the CURRENT, post-2025 rate of Rs 2.81 lakh a month - the most generous possible assumption, and still not close.



Sources: ADR asset comparison of 324 re-contesting MPs (avg Rs 21.55 cr in 2019 to Rs 30.88 cr in 2024). Pay per Salary, Allowances and Pension of Members of Parliament Act, 1954, as revised 2025: Rs 1.24 lakh salary + Rs 87,000 constituency + Rs 75,000 office = Rs 2.86 lakh; Rs 2.81 lakh used. Taxes and living costs ignored, again in their favour.

I have deliberately used the current, post-2025 pay scale - the most generous assumption available to them - and still ignored tax and living costs entirely. The gap is not sensitive to any of that.

Rs 1.69 crore came in through the front door. Rs 9.33 crore appeared. The difference is Rs 7.64 crore per MP, on average, that the job did not pay them.

Nobody has to prove anything corrupt happened. The arithmetic simply has no other column to put it in.

There are honest explanations for individual cases. Some MPs are genuinely successful businesspeople whose companies grew. Some inherited. Some married. Property in the right district revalued. I am not accusing any specific person of anything, and I want that on the record. But we are looking at an **average across 324 people**. When a phenomenon appears at the mean, "some of them had good years" stops being an explanation and starts being an evasion.

And it compounds

Take the longer window. Of the MPs re-elected between 2014 and 2024, the average growth in declared assets over the decade was 110 per cent. Their assets, in aggregate, roughly doubled.

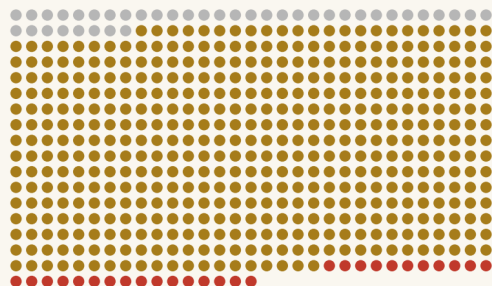
At the state level it is worse in the places you would expect. Re-contesting MLAs across states between 2017 and 2022 averaged 56 per cent asset growth. In Arunachal Pradesh, the re-elected BJP MLAs' average assets grew by 919 per cent in five years. Nine hundred and nineteen per cent. Somebody wrote that number down in an affidavit, signed it, submitted it to the Election Commission, and got elected again.

What the House looks like now

// the House

Ninety-three per cent of the Lok Sabha are crorepatis.

One dot, one MP. Average declared assets: Rs 46.34 crore - roughly 2,150 times India's annual per-capita income.



● 54 under Rs 1 crore 477 Rs 1 cr to Rs 100 Over Rs 100 crore

Source: ADR analysis of 2024 Lok Sabha winning candidates. Bands derived from published shares: 93% crorepati, 5% above Rs 100 crore. Per-capita income approximate (NSO, 2023-24).

Five hundred and forty-three dots. Five hundred and four of them are crorepatis.

Ninety-three per cent of the Lok Sabha are crorepatis. The average declared assets of an MP are Rs 46.34 crore - which is roughly 2,150 times India's annual per capita income. Twenty-seven MPs, five per cent of the House, declare assets above Rs 100 crore.

This is a legislature drawn from the top fraction of a fraction of a per cent of the country it legislates for. It is entitled to be, in the sense that voters chose it. But we should stop pretending it is broadly representative, and we should be extremely curious about the mechanism by which a job paying Rs 2.81 lakh a month reliably produces this outcome.

04

// the product

What fear is actually for

Here is a question I think people ask backwards. They ask: why are our politicians so divisive? The better question is: what job is division doing for them?

Consider what a candidate has to sell. If you are unqualified for the portfolio you are seeking, you cannot campaign on competence, because you have none to demonstrate and no way to demonstrate it if you did. You cannot campaign on your record, because your record is a file the department wrote. You cannot campaign on a plan, because a plan invites the question of whether you understand it.

What you can do, cheaply, at scale, and with a five-year shelf life, is tell a large group of people that a different group of people is coming for them.

Fear is the only campaign product that requires zero domain knowledge to manufacture and zero delivery to sustain.

That is the whole mechanism. It is not that politicians are unusually cruel people. It is that in a market where competence is unobservable and unverifiable, the only differentiated product left is identity threat. A candidate who spent thirty years building water infrastructure and a candidate who has never read a document are, from the voter's seat, **indistinguishable** - because there is no instrument that distinguishes them. So the second candidate competes on the axis where they can win.

The economics of a manufactured enemy

Fear has properties that make it an unusually good product for a low-quality supplier.

- It is non-falsifiable. If the threatened catastrophe does not occur, that is proof of your vigilance. If it does, that is proof you were right.
- It has no delivery cost. A road has to exist. A grievance does not.
- It is renewable. The same enemy can be sold in the next cycle at no additional cost of goods.

- It suppresses the competence question entirely. Nobody asks the man on the wall about his fiscal policy.

Now overlay this on the previous chapter. A candidate whose primary asset is coercive capacity, running in a market where the winning product is identity threat, entering an office with no competence test at the door. Each piece makes the others work better. It is a remarkably well-designed machine. It was simply designed for the wrong objective.

The part I want to be careful about

I do not think this is unique to India and I do not think any one party invented it. Every large democracy with weak candidate-quality signals produces some version of this, and the ones with strong signals - Singapore's technocratic filter, Germany's party-list apprenticeship, even the American practice of governors as presidential feedstock - produce measurably less of it. The variable is not national character. The variable is what the selection mechanism can see.

05

// the day job

The legislature that stopped reading

Suppose you disagree with everything above. Suppose you think the wealth is coincidence and the criminality is persecution. Fine. Look at the output instead.

// the day job

The legislature has largely stopped reading its own laws.

17th Lok Sabha, June 2019 to February 2024. It sat for 274 days across five years - an average of 55 days a year, against 135 in the first Lok Sabha.



of bills passed with
no committee scrutiny



of bills passed after
under one hour of debate



of bills passed within
two weeks of introduction

Source: PRS Legislative Research, Functioning of the 17th Lok Sabha.

The 17th Lok Sabha, June 2019 to February 2024, as measured by PRS Legislative Research.

Eighty-four per cent of bills in the 17th Lok Sabha were passed with no committee scrutiny at all. Thirty-five per cent were passed after less than one hour of debate. Fifty-eight per cent were passed within a fortnight of being introduced.

The House sat for 274 days across five years. That is an average of 55 sitting days a year. The first Lok Sabha averaged 135.

What that actually means

A parliamentary standing committee is where a bill meets people who know things. Officials are questioned. Industry is heard. Academics submit. Drafting errors get

caught. It is slow, boring, largely invisible work, and it is close to the entire value-add of a legislature over an executive decree.

Sixteen per cent of bills went there.

The rest were introduced, debated for a period shorter than a film, and passed - frequently without a recorded division, so we do not even know who was in the room. A law that reshapes the labour market or the criminal code or the tax base got less deliberative attention than a mid-sized company gives to a procurement contract.

THIS IS THE STRONGEST EVIDENCE IN THE REPORT

The wealth data can be argued about. The criminality data can be argued about. This cannot. This is the House's own record of its own work, and it says that the institution has largely stopped performing the function that justifies its existence. You do not need my theory about why. You just need to look at the number.

And it connects straight back. A chamber that cannot read a bill cannot amend one, cannot resist one, and cannot be persuaded by evidence about one. What is left is a voting machine attached to a whip. Which is exactly what you would build if you were selecting members for loyalty and reach rather than for the capacity to do the job.

06

// the bill

What the show costs

The 2024 general election is estimated to have cost around **Rs 1.35 lakh crore** - all in, across parties, candidates, government and the Election Commission. That is the Centre for Media Studies estimate, and it made this the most expensive election ever held anywhere. Per voter on the roll, it works out to roughly Rs 1,400. The 2020 United States presidential cycle cost about USD 14.4 billion, which is less.

Where did it come from? Partly, for six years, from an instrument specifically designed so that nobody could find out.

The electoral bonds interval

The Electoral Bond Scheme allowed a donor to buy a bearer instrument from the State Bank of India and hand it to a political party, with the donor's identity shielded from the public, from the Election Commission and from rival parties - but not, as it turned out, from the government of the day, which controlled the bank. Rs 16,518 crore was sold across thirty tranches.

On 15 February 2024, a five-judge Constitution Bench struck it down as unconstitutional, holding that it violated the voter's right to information under Article 19(1)(a).

The Supreme Court's reasoning was that a voter cannot evaluate a candidate without knowing who is paying for the candidate. I would like to extend that reasoning by one step.

Because that is exactly the argument I am making in this report, applied to a different unknown. The Court said: you cannot judge a candidate you cannot see the funding of. I am saying: you cannot judge a candidate you cannot see the *capability* of. It is the same information-asymmetry argument, and the Court has already accepted it once, at the highest possible level, in the context of the same ballot.

The scale mismatch

India is willing to spend Rs 1.35 lakh crore on the process of choosing. It spends nothing at all on generating information about what is being chosen between.

Hold that thought until Chapter 13, where I cost the alternative. The answer, roughly, is that testing every serious candidate in the country - written papers, portfolio papers, a full psychometric battery, boards, publication, appeals, the lot - comes to about one and a half per cent of what we already spend running the election itself.

PART II

The system

What I would actually build, in enough detail that you can find the holes in it.

07

// the proposal

The one-page version

Five gates. Here is the whole thing.

// the proposal

Five gates. Only the first one can stop you.

Gates 2 and 3 set a floor and publish your exact mark above it. Gate 4 publishes and never bars.
Gate 5 is untouched.

1	Eligibility and disclosure Citizen, 25 or over, on the roll. No framed charge for a serious offence. Full asset and income disclosure.	HARD BAR
2	Common Governance Aptitude Test Constitution and law, public finance, quantitative reasoning, applied ethics. A floor to clear, and your exact score put	FLOOR + PUBLISHED SCORE
3	Portfolio Competence Examination One paper per ministry you want to be eligible to hold. A floor for each, and your exact score published for each.	FLOOR + PUBLISHED SCORE
4	Psychometric and integrity battery Published as a band with a written board note. Never a bare number, and never, ever a bar.	PUBLISHED ONLY - NEVER A BAR
5	The vote Universal adult franchise, entirely unchanged. The voter now decides with the file open.	THE DECISION

The architecture. Note carefully what each gate can and cannot do - the distinctions are the entire design.

Gate 1 - Eligibility. This one can bar you.

Citizen, twenty-five or over, on an electoral roll. No **framed charge** - not an FIR, a charge framed by a court - for an offence carrying a maximum sentence of five years or more. Full asset, income and liability disclosure for self and immediate family, filed and published. This is essentially the Law Commission's 244th Report recommendation, which India has had sitting on a shelf since February 2014.

Gate 2 - The Common Governance Aptitude Test. A floor, and a published score.

One paper, sat by every candidate for any legislature. Constitution and administrative law, public finance, quantitative and statistical reasoning, and applied ethics. There is a floor you must clear to stand. Above the floor, your exact mark is published next to your name on every ballot-related document that exists.

Gate 3 - Portfolio Competence Examinations. A floor per ministry, and a published score per ministry.

A separate paper for each portfolio you wish to be **eligible to hold**. You may sit as many as you like. You may sit none, in which case you may still stand for the legislature and still vote in it - you simply cannot be appointed to run a ministry you have not qualified for. Each mark is published.

Gate 4 - The psychometric and integrity battery. Published. Never a bar.

A full battery, reported as a band with a written board note. It can never disqualify anybody from anything. I will defend this restriction at length in Chapter 11, because it is the single most likely place for this whole proposal to turn into something ugly.

Gate 5 - The vote. Completely unchanged.

Universal adult franchise. Every voter, no test, no filter, no weighting. The voter now decides with the file open in front of them, and remains entirely free to elect the candidate who scored thirty-one per cent. That is their right and I would not touch it.

THE ONE-SENTENCE SUMMARY

Standing for a legislature requires clearing a low general floor; running a ministry requires having passed that ministry's paper; and every number generated along the way belongs to the public, not to the state.

08

// the hinge

The constitutional argument

The usual first response to this proposal is that it is unconstitutional. It is not, and the reason is more interesting than I expected when I went looking.

Article 84(c) already says you can do this

Article 84 of the Constitution sets out the qualifications for membership of Parliament. Citizenship. Age - thirty for the Council of States, twenty-five for the House of the People. And then, at clause (c): **"such other qualifications as may be prescribed in that behalf by or under any law made by Parliament."**

That clause is a blank cheque, written by the framers, that has essentially never been cashed. Parliament has the express constitutional power to prescribe further qualifications for its own members. It has simply chosen not to prescribe any.

Rajbala v. State of Haryana

In December 2015, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court decided *Rajbala v. State of Haryana*. Haryana had amended its Panchayati Raj Act to require minimum educational qualifications, a functional toilet at home, no outstanding electricity dues and no outstanding cooperative bank loans, in order to contest panchayat elections. It was challenged as arbitrary and discriminatory.

The Court upheld it. And in doing so it held something considerably more consequential than the outcome:

The right to contest an election is not a fundamental right. It is a right conferred by statute, and it may be conditioned by statute.

That is the hinge. If the right to contest were a fundamental right under Part III, any qualification test would face strict scrutiny and would very probably fail. Because it is a statutory right, the test is the far more forgiving one of whether the classification is reasonable and bears a rational nexus to the object sought.

I SHOULD FLAG THE CRITICISM, BECAUSE IT IS SERIOUS

Rajbala was heavily criticised - for its reasoning on educational qualifications in a country with the literacy distribution India has, for treating a toilet and a bank loan as proxies for civic fitness, and for the effect it had of excluding large numbers of poor, rural and disproportionately female candidates. I think much of that criticism is correct as applied to Haryana's specific criteria. It does not touch the holding I am relying on, which is about the legal character of the right, not about whether Haryana chose sensible conditions. And it is a genuine warning about how badly this can be done.

What that means in practice

An examination requirement is a far better fit for the Rajbala test than the criteria Haryana actually used. A toilet has no rational nexus to legislative capability; a paper on public finance for a person seeking to run public finance has an extremely direct one. A property qualification excludes on the basis of an accident of birth; an examination is, at least in principle, open to anyone who prepares.

Article 102 and the machinery that already exists

Article 102 sets out disqualifications, and Section 8 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 fills in the detail - the conviction-based disqualifications that currently apply. So the architecture for conditioning candidacy is not novel. It exists, it is used, and it is litigated regularly. I am proposing to add a qualification limb to a structure that already has a well-worn disqualification limb.

What would still need amending

Two things, honestly.

- Article 75(5) and Article 164(4) - the provisions allowing a person who is not a member of either House to be appointed a Minister for six months. Gate 3 would need to bind that appointment route too, or it becomes the obvious bypass.
- Anti-defection and the Tenth Schedule interact awkwardly with a system where a member's portfolio eligibility is a personal attribute rather than a party gift. That needs thought I have not fully done.

Everything else, I think, is ordinary legislation under Article 84(c) plus a matching provision for state legislatures under Article 173(c).

The Common Governance Aptitude Test

This is the paper everybody sits. It is deliberately not hard. It is a floor, not a tournament.

Structure

Three hours. 200 marks. Computer-based, delivered in all twenty-two scheduled languages plus English, at any UPSC or NTA centre, on demand, at least four windows a year. Negative marking on multiple choice at one-third. Two written sections marked blind by two independent examiners with a third on disagreement.

What is actually on it

MODULE	MARKS	FORMAT
Constitution and administrative law	50	Multiple choice and short answer
Public finance and budgeting	50	Multiple choice, plus one numerical case
Quantitative and statistical reasoning	50	Multiple choice, calculator permitted
Applied ethics and conflict of interest	50	Two written scenarios, 500 words each

Constitution and administrative law. The structure of the Union and the States. The Seventh Schedule and who is allowed to legislate on what. Fundamental rights and the tests courts apply to restrictions on them. How a bill becomes an Act. What a money bill is and why it matters. Emergency provisions. The basic structure doctrine and what it does. Ordinance-making power and its limits. Judicial review. The office of the CAG, the Election Commission, the UPSC.

Public finance and budgeting. How to read a budget document. Revenue versus capital expenditure and why the distinction is routinely abused. Fiscal deficit, revenue deficit, primary deficit - what each measures and what each conceals. Debt-to-GDP

and debt sustainability. The FRBM framework. Centre-state transfers and the Finance Commission. GST and its council. Contingent liabilities and off-balance-sheet borrowing. How to read a CAG report.

Quantitative and statistical reasoning. Percentages and percentage points, which one third of Parliament appears to conflate. Compounding. Per capita versus aggregate. Mean, median and why the difference matters when you are talking about income. Sampling and sampling error. Confidence intervals. Base rates. Correlation and causation, tested with actual traps. Reading a chart with a truncated axis and identifying what has been done to you.

Applied ethics and conflict of interest. Two written scenarios. What a conflict of interest is, and why disclosure is not the same as resolution. When a public official may accept a thing of value, which is essentially never. Quid pro quo versus structural capture. The revolving door. What you do when your party's position and the evidence diverge.

A sample item from each module, so you can see the level

CONSTITUTION

A Bill is introduced in the Lok Sabha. It contains a provision imposing a cess, and separately, a provision creating a new regulatory authority with powers of search and seizure. The Speaker certifies it as a Money Bill. State whether that certification is available on these facts, cite the relevant Article, and state what remedy, if any, is available to the Rajya Sabha. (10 marks)

PUBLIC FINANCE

A state government funds a Rs 20,000 crore irrigation programme by having a state-owned corporation borrow the money against a government guarantee, with the state undertaking to service the debt from future budgets. The state's reported fiscal deficit is unchanged. Explain, in no more than 200 words, what has actually happened to the state's fiscal position and where a reader would find it. (10 marks)

QUANTITATIVE

A scheme reports that beneficiary enrolment rose from 4 per cent to 6 per cent of the eligible population. A press release describes this as a "50 per cent increase in coverage". A second press release describes it as a "2 per cent increase in coverage". State whether each is correct, and state the single number you would want before deciding whether the scheme is working. (5 marks)

ETHICS

You are a Minister. Your department is finalising a tender. Your brother-in-law's firm is one of four bidders. You have no shareholding in it and you have taken no part in the evaluation. A journalist asks you to comment. Set out, with reasons, what you should have done at the point you learned of the bid, what you should do now, and why recusal alone may be insufficient. (25 marks)

The floor is 40 per cent aggregate with 30 per cent in each module. I want to be clear about how low that is. This is not designed to select the brilliant. It is designed to exclude the person who does not know what a fiscal deficit is and is asking to vote on one.

10

// paper two

The Portfolio Competence Examinations

This is the heart of it, and it is the part the current system has no analogue for whatsoever.

One paper per portfolio. Sit as many as you want. Each is three hours, 200 marks, and the mark you get is published beside your name for the rest of your career. The floor for eligibility to be appointed to that ministry is 50 per cent.

// the syllabus

No two ministries should sit the same paper.

Weight of each module in the Portfolio Competence Examination, as a percentage of the paper. Fourteen of the ministries are shown; the full schedule runs to every Union portfolio.

	Constitutional & legal	Public finance & budgeting	Domain technical core	Data & quantitative	Delivery & procurement	Ethics & conflict
Finance	15	30	20	20	5	10
Home Affairs	25	10	25	10	20	10
Defence	15	15	30	10	20	10
External Affairs	20	10	35	10	15	10
Health & Family Welfare	10	15	30	20	15	10
Education	10	15	30	20	15	10
Agriculture	10	20	30	15	15	10
Railways	10	20	25	15	20	10
Power & Renewables	10	20	30	15	15	10
Environment & Climate	15	10	35	20	10	10
Electronics & IT	15	10	35	20	10	10
Law & Justice	40	5	30	5	10	10
Commerce & Industry	15	20	30	15	10	10
Road Transport	10	20	25	15	20	10

Proposed weights. Mine, not anyone else's - argue with them, that is the point of publishing them.

Module weightings by ministry, as a percentage of the paper. Fourteen shown; the full schedule would cover every Union portfolio and their state equivalents.

The six modules are constant across every paper. What changes is the weighting and, obviously, the content of the domain core. Below is what I would put in each.

Finance

The job: setting the fiscal stance for a USD 4 trillion economy, taxing it, and owning the consequences.

Domain core: tax policy design and incidence. Direct and indirect tax architecture. GST design and the compensation problem. Public debt management and the maturity profile. Monetary-fiscal coordination and the limits of it. Banking regulation, capital adequacy, and how a non-performing asset actually forms. Financial stability and systemic risk. Disinvestment and asset monetisation. Subsidy design and targeting. Reading consolidated accounts.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Inflation is running at 6.2 per cent, above the upper tolerance band. Growth has slowed to 5.1 per cent. The rupee has depreciated 7 per cent in six months and foreign exchange reserves cover eight months of imports. Set out the fiscal options available to you, the transmission channel of each, the principal risk of each, and which you would choose. State explicitly what would have to be true for your choice to be wrong. (50 marks)

Home Affairs

The job: internal security, policing, the federal relationship, and the coercive power of the state.

Domain core: criminal law and procedure, including the new criminal codes. Police organisation, accountability and the Prakash Singh directives. Centre-state security relations and Article 355. Central armed police forces. Internal security in insurgency-affected areas. Border management. Disaster management. Citizenship and foreigners law. Communal violence prevention. Custodial death and the law on it. Surveillance law and its limits.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A state government requests central forces to control communal violence. Set out the constitutional basis on which the Union may deploy, the limits on that power, the chain of command once deployed, and the accountability route for any use of lethal force. Then explain what changes in your answer if the state government has NOT requested deployment. (50 marks)

Defence

The job: the armed forces, procurement, and civilian control of the largest instrument the state owns.

Domain core: force structure and jointness. Defence procurement procedure, life-cycle costing and offsets. The indigenous defence industrial base. Nuclear doctrine and command and control. Cyber and space as domains. Military justice and its interface with civilian courts. Veterans and pensions as a fiscal object. Civil-military relations doctrine.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

You are presented with two options for a 114-aircraft requirement: an off-the-shelf foreign purchase deliverable in four years at a stated unit cost, and a domestic co-production route deliverable in nine years at a 40 per cent higher unit cost. Set out the full life-cycle comparison you would demand before deciding, name the three assumptions in it most likely to be wrong, and explain what industrial-base value, if any, justifies paying a premium. (50 marks)

External Affairs

The job: representing the country, negotiating for it, and not accidentally starting anything.

Domain core: treaty law and the domestic incorporation of international obligations. The neighbourhood: each bordering state's outstanding disputes and the current legal position on each. Multilateral architecture and India's positions. Trade negotiation mechanics and WTO law. Sanctions regimes and secondary sanctions exposure. Diaspora and consular law. Maritime law and UNCLOS. Climate negotiation positions and the equity arguments underlying them.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

India has signed a bilateral investment treaty containing an investor-state dispute settlement clause. A foreign investor initiates arbitration over a state government's cancellation of a mining lease. Explain the Union's exposure, the doctrine under which a sub-national act binds the Union internationally, and the drafting change you would demand in future treaties. (50 marks)

Health and Family Welfare

The job: the health of 1.4 billion people, most of whom pay out of pocket.

Domain core: epidemiology, including prevalence, incidence, case fatality and excess mortality. Health financing and out-of-pocket expenditure. Insurance design and moral hazard. Drug pricing and compulsory licensing. Clinical trial regulation and ethics. Vaccine policy, cold chain and hesitancy. Antimicrobial resistance. Primary care versus tertiary care allocation. Health workforce economics. Disease surveillance systems. Reading a randomised trial and a meta-analysis.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A new drug reduces relative risk of a common outcome by 30 per cent in a trial of 800 patients. Baseline absolute risk is 2 per cent. The drug costs Rs 40,000 per course. Calculate the number needed to treat, estimate the cost per event averted, and state the three further pieces of information you would require before adding it to the essential medicines list. (50 marks)

Education

The job: 250 million children, and whether they can read.

Domain core: learning outcome measurement and what ASER-type surveys actually show. Curriculum and pedagogy at scale. Teacher recruitment, training, absenteeism and incentives. Foundational literacy and numeracy. Higher education regulation, accreditation and autonomy. Vocational and skills architecture. Education financing and the private-school shift. Language policy. Assessment design and the harm of high-stakes testing. Evidence standards in education research, which are poor.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A state reports that 95 per cent of Class 5 children are enrolled, and an independent survey reports that 42 per cent of them cannot read a Class 2 text. Both are accurate. Explain how, identify which of the two is the policy-relevant number, and design a measurement regime you would not be able to game. (50 marks)

Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare

The job: the livelihood of the largest occupational group in the country.

Domain core: cropping systems, soil health and water tables. Minimum support price mechanics, procurement and its fiscal cost. Fertiliser subsidy design and its consequences for soil and for the exchequer. Agricultural marketing, mandis and the APMC question. Crop insurance and basis risk. Irrigation and groundwater economics. Farm credit and indebtedness. Land holdings, tenancy and fragmentation. Agri-trade and export bans. Climate adaptation for agriculture.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Groundwater in a major agricultural state is falling one metre a year, driven substantially by a free-electricity policy and a procurement guarantee for a water-intensive crop. Design a transition that does not reduce farmer incomes in year one, state its fiscal cost over five years, and identify the political constituency that will oppose it and what you would offer them. (50 marks)

Railways

The job: the largest civilian employer in the country, running a network that cannot be shut for maintenance.

Domain core: network capacity, line utilisation and pathing. Freight versus passenger cross-subsidy and its magnitude. Signalling technology and safety systems. Rolling stock procurement and maintenance cycles. Station redevelopment and land monetisation. Dedicated freight corridors. Tariff design. Safety investigation methodology and accident causation. Railway finances and the operating ratio, including how it is massaged.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

The operating ratio is reported at 98.1 per cent. Explain precisely what that number includes and excludes, name two accounting choices that materially affect it, and state what you would need to see to judge whether the network is being maintained or consumed. (50 marks)

Power and Renewable Energy

The job: keeping the lights on while changing what turns them on.

Domain core: grid operation, frequency, balancing and inertia. Levelised cost of energy and its limits as a comparison tool. Storage economics. Discom finances, aggregate technical and commercial losses, and the recurring bailout cycle. Power purchase agreements and stranded assets. Coal supply and the transition problem. Renewable integration and curtailment. Nuclear regulation and liability law. Transmission planning. Tariff-setting and cross-subsidy.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Solar generation is now cheaper per unit than coal on a levelised basis in your state, yet the distribution company continues to buy coal power at a higher unit cost. Give three reasons why this may be entirely rational, and explain which of them a subsidy could fix and which it could not. (50 marks)

Environment, Forest and Climate Change

The job: the part of the ledger nobody bills until it is too late.

Domain core: environmental clearance law and the EIA process. Forest rights and the Forest Rights Act. Air quality science, source apportionment and monitoring. Water quality and effluent regulation. Climate science fundamentals and India's mitigation and adaptation commitments. Carbon markets and their failure modes. Biodiversity and protected area management. Environmental economics, externalities and pricing. Waste management. The National Green Tribunal and its jurisprudence.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A city's PM2.5 concentration is four times the WHO guideline. You have a budget sufficient to address roughly one third of measured emissions. Explain how you would use source apportionment to allocate it, why the largest source may not be the best target, and how you would prevent the measurement network being relocated to improve the numbers. (50 marks)

Electronics and Information Technology

The job: the rules for the infrastructure everything else now runs on.

Domain core: data protection law and its exemptions. Intermediary liability and safe harbour. Encryption and lawful access. Surveillance law and oversight. Digital public infrastructure - identity, payments, data exchange - and its failure modes. Semiconductor supply chains and industrial policy. AI governance. Platform competition. Cybersecurity and critical infrastructure protection. Telecom spectrum allocation and auction design.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A data protection statute grants the Union government power to exempt any agency from its application by notification, on grounds including sovereignty and public order. Explain what this does to the statute's protective effect, identify the constitutional test such an exemption would have to satisfy under Puttaswamy, and draft the safeguard you would insert. (50 marks)

Law and Justice

The job: the courts, the codes, and the queue.

Domain core: constitutional law in depth. Judicial appointments and the collegium debate. Case pendency: its actual causes, judge-population ratio, vacancy rates, adjournment practice. Alternative dispute resolution. Legal aid and access to justice. Criminal justice reform, undertrial population and bail jurisprudence. Legislative drafting. Subordinate legislation and excessive delegation. Tribunalisation and its constitutional limits.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Five crore cases are pending. Assess the claim that this is primarily caused by judicial vacancies, using the arithmetic of filing rates, disposal rates and per-judge productivity. Then identify the two interventions you believe have the largest effect per rupee, and state the evidence base for each. (50 marks)

Commerce and Industry

The job: trade policy, and the industrial policy nobody calls industrial policy.

Domain core: trade theory and comparative advantage. Tariff structure, inverted duty and effective protection. Free trade agreement negotiation and rules of origin. WTO law and dispute settlement. Export promotion schemes and WTO compatibility. Production-linked incentives - design, cost and evaluation. Special economic zones. Anti-dumping and trade remedies. Foreign direct investment policy. Global value chain positioning. Ease of doing business as a measured object.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A production-linked incentive scheme has disbursed Rs 8,000 crore and the sector's output has risen 30 per cent. Explain why this does not establish the scheme worked, specify the counterfactual you would need, and describe an evaluation design that could be run without a control group. (50 marks)

Road Transport and Highways

The job: the largest capital programme in the country, and the people it kills.

Domain core: road safety engineering and the systems approach to fatalities. Highway financing models - BOT, HAM, EPC - and where risk actually sits in each. Toll policy. Land acquisition and compensation law. Vehicle regulation and emission standards. Freight logistics costs. Public transport and modal share. Construction

quality assurance. Traffic modelling and demand forecast error, which is systematically optimistic.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

India records roughly 1.7 lakh road deaths a year. Rank the following by expected lives saved per rupee and justify the ranking: divided-carriageway retrofits on high-fatality corridors, helmet law enforcement, trauma care response times, and heavy-vehicle speed governors. State what data you would need to check whether you are right. (50 marks)

Petroleum and Natural Gas

The job: the import bill, the pump price, and the thing that funds a chunk of the exchequer.

Domain core: upstream exploration economics and fiscal regimes. Refining margins and complexity. Import dependence and strategic reserves. Pricing mechanisms and the history of deregulation. Excise structure and revenue dependence. Gas pricing, pipelines and city gas distribution. LNG contracting. Biofuel blending. The transition risk to a fiscally significant sector.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Crude rises USD 20 a barrel. Quantify the effect on the current account, on retail prices if the excise structure is unchanged, and on central revenue if excise is cut to hold the pump price flat. State which of the three you would prioritise protecting and why. (50 marks)

Women and Child Development

The job: the largest nutrition programme in the world, and the law on violence.

Domain core: nutrition science - stunting, wasting, anaemia, the first thousand days. ICDS and anganwadi delivery. Maternal and child health. The law on domestic violence, sexual offences and POCSO, and the gap between statute and conviction. Child protection systems. Female labour force participation and what actually moves it. Care economy measurement. Gender budgeting. Adolescent health.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Stunting has fallen but anaemia has risen in the same survey round. Explain how both can be true, what each measures, which is more responsive to a food-based intervention, and what you would change in the supplementary nutrition programme in response. (50 marks)

Labour and Employment

The job: the ninety per cent of the workforce that the labour laws never covered.

Domain core: the labour codes and what consolidation changed. Informality: its measurement, its causes and why it persists. Social security architecture and portability. Minimum wage theory and the employment effect evidence. Industrial relations and dispute resolution. Occupational safety. Migration, interstate workers and entitlement portability. Gig and platform work classification. Employment data sources and their known problems. Skilling and its dismal evaluation record.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

Unemployment is reported at 3.2 per cent while labour force participation is 42 per cent. Explain why the first number is nearly uninformative on its own, define the measure you would use instead, and state what it would take for a jobs programme to raise it. (50 marks)

Statistics and Programme Implementation

The job: the numbers everyone else in this chapter depends on.

Domain core: national accounts methodology and revisions. Survey design, sampling frames and non-response. Census operations. Price index construction and base year revision. Statistical independence and the case for it. Administrative data quality. Data dissemination and the case for open microdata. The specific controversies in Indian statistics over the last decade and the arguments on both sides.

SIGNATURE QUESTION

A survey shows a result politically inconvenient to the government of the day. Set out the procedural protections that should determine whether it is published, who should hold the decision, and why a Minister holding it is a category error. Then explain what you would do if you personally believed the survey was methodologically flawed. (50 marks)

And the two that are different

Head of Government - Prime Minister or Chief Minister. No single domain paper is appropriate. Instead: a mandatory pass in the Common Governance Aptitude Test at 65 per cent rather than 40, plus any three portfolio papers at 60 per cent, plus a five-hour written command exercise in which the candidate is given a genuine multi-ministry crisis file and must produce a decision note, a resource allocation and a communication plan, marked by a mixed board.

Presiding Officer - Speaker or Chairman. A paper on parliamentary procedure, privilege, the Tenth Schedule, the rules of debate and the jurisprudence on the

Speaker's discretion, at 70 per cent. This is a job made almost entirely of technical procedural knowledge and we currently award it as a consolation prize.

11

// paper three

The psychometric battery, and its leash

This is the chapter where I disagree with the version of this idea that most people have in their heads, including the version I started with.

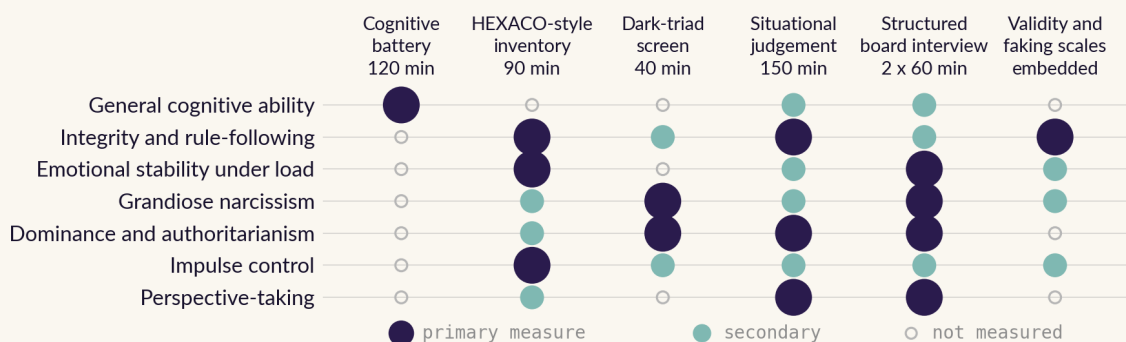
The intuition is obvious and correct: we would like to know whether the person asking for coercive power over 1.4 billion people is a grandiose narcissist with poor impulse control and a taste for dominance. That is genuinely useful information. Psychology can measure those constructs with meaningful, replicated reliability. It would be strange to refuse to look.

The problem is not measurement. The problem is what happens next.

// the battery

What the psychological testing is actually for.

Not to find good people. To find the specific dispositions that predict abuse of a public office, and to put them on the record.



Instruments named are the established public-domain or licensed families the battery would be built from; item content would be commissioned and rotated. Every instrument carries embedded validity scales because everyone taking this test has an obvious incentive to fake good.

What each instrument in the battery is actually for. Nothing here is exotic; these are established instrument families used in high-stakes selection today.

What the battery contains

A cognitive battery, two hours, measuring general reasoning - the one construct in all of psychology with genuinely excellent predictive validity for complex job performance. A HEXACO-style personality inventory, ninety minutes, with honesty-humility as the facet that matters most here. A dark-triad screen, forty minutes. A situational judgement test built specifically on governance scenarios, two and a half hours, which is the instrument I would weight most heavily because it is the hardest to coach and the closest to the actual job. Two structured board interviews of an hour each, with trained assessors working to a rubric, recorded. And validity scales embedded throughout, because every single person taking this test has a screaming incentive to fake good, and any battery that does not assume that is a decoration.

India already runs something close to this, well, at scale. The Services Selection Board process assesses candidates against fifteen Officer Like Qualities grouped into four factors, over five days, using projective techniques, group tasks and a personal interview, with three independent assessors who confer only at the end. It is not perfect. It is a serious, functioning, decades-old apparatus, and the idea that India could not administer such a thing is simply false.

Why it must never be a bar

And now the leash. **Gate 4 can never disqualify anybody from anything.** Not a low band, not a bad board note, not a validity-scale flag. It publishes, and that is the whole of its power.

Three reasons, in ascending order of how much they worry me.

- **The instruments are not good enough for a binary decision.** Personality inventories have real validity for aggregate prediction and poor validity for individual classification. A test that correlates 0.3 with a behavioural outcome is scientifically useful and morally unfit to end a career. Cognitive tests are better, which is why they can inform Gate 2's floor, but the personality battery cannot.
- **Faking is not a bug you can engineer out.** Serious candidates will be coached. The coaching industry that will grow around this within eighteen months will be very good, and the arms race between item writers and coaches is one the coaches eventually win because they only have to solve the published items. Validity scales help and do not solve it.
- **A body that can bar you for your personality will eventually bar you for your politics.** This is the one that actually matters, and it is not speculative.

// the objection that lands

A body that vets candidates will eventually vet for loyalty.

Share of registered candidates disqualified by Iran's Guardian Council before the ballot was printed. This is the failure mode, and it is not hypothetical.



Sources: reported Guardian Council vetting outcomes. 2024 Majlis: about 15,200 of roughly 37,000 registrants approved. 2024 Assembly of Experts: 138 of 510. 2016 Assembly of Experts: about 80% rejected.

Iran's Guardian Council is the fully-developed form of the thing I am refusing to build. It began as a constitutional vetting body and became a loyalty filter.

In 2024, Iran's Guardian Council approved about 15,200 of roughly 37,000 registered parliamentary candidates - it disqualified 59 per cent of the people who wanted to stand. For the Assembly of Experts the same year, 510 registered and 138 were approved. In 2016 it rejected around 80 per cent of Assembly of Experts applicants. The published criteria are about competence and commitment. The operative criterion is loyalty, and everybody in Iran knows it.

Every vetting body in history that could exclude on a soft criterion eventually excluded on the softest criterion available to it, which is whether the regime likes you.

"Psychological unsuitability" is the softest criterion imaginable. It is unfalsifiable, it is expert-certified, it is unappealable in practice, and it sounds responsible. If you give a state the power to bar a candidate on those grounds, you have handed it the perfect instrument and it will be used within a decade. I would rather have the information published and the power withheld.

The publication rules

Bands, not scores. Five bands per construct, with the band boundaries pre-registered and published before any candidate sits. A written board note of no more than 300 words per candidate, in plain language, published verbatim. The raw responses are destroyed after the appeal window. No clinical diagnosis is ever recorded, made or published - this is a selection instrument, not a psychiatric assessment, and confusing

the two would be both scientifically illiterate and cruel. A candidate may publish their own rebuttal alongside, of equal length, and it must be carried wherever the band is carried.

WHY PUBLISH AT ALL, IF IT CANNOT BAR

Because the entire theory of this proposal is that the voter is not stupid, the voter is uninformed. Publication changes the price of a low band from zero to something. A candidate who scores in the bottom band for impulse control and the top band for dominance has not been disqualified from anything - they have simply been described, accurately, in public, by an instrument they agreed to sit. What the electorate does with that is the electorate's business.

12

// the machinery

The scorecard and the Commission

Two practical questions remain: what does the voter actually see, and who runs this without being captured.

The scorecard

One page. Standard format, prescribed by statute, identical for every candidate in the country. It carries: name, party, age, education, declared assets and liabilities with the year-on-year change, every pending framed charge with the section and the court, the CGAT score out of 200 with the module breakdown, every portfolio paper attempted with the mark, the psychometric bands with the board note, attendance and questions asked in the previous term if any, and the candidate's own 300-word statement, unedited.

It is printed at every polling station. It is on the back of the voter slip. It is on a public API. It is read out on demand in the local language at the booth for voters who prefer that.

The Commission

An Election Integrity and Assessment Commission, separate from the Election Commission, which has enough to do. Structure matters more than intention here, so:

- Members appointed by a collegium of the Chief Justice, the Leader of the Opposition, the Speaker, the Prime Minister and the Chairperson of the UPSC. Any appointment requires four of five.
- Fixed non-renewable seven-year terms. Removal only by the process applicable to a Supreme Court judge. No post-retirement government appointment, ever, for anybody who has served.
- Funded by a charge on the Consolidated Fund, not an annual vote, so the budget cannot be used as a lever.

- Item-setting done by rotating panels of academics under blind commission, with panel identities published only after the paper is used and no panel serving twice in a row.
- Every paper, every key and every candidate's marked script published in full after the result, with the candidate's name redacted only at the candidate's request. Total transparency is the only defence against a rigged paper.
- A statutory duty to publish an annual report on differential pass rates by gender, caste, religion, language, region and income. If the instrument is producing disparate impact, that becomes visible immediately rather than in a doctoral thesis fifteen years later.

That last one matters enormously and I will come back to it in Chapter 16, because it is where the strongest objection to this entire project lives.

PART III

The hard part

What it costs, how you get there, and every reason it might not work.

13

// the bill

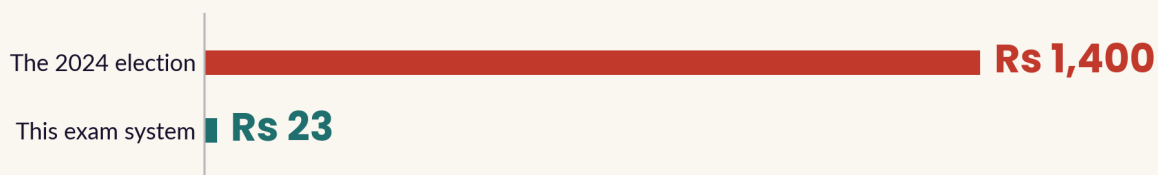
What it costs

I expected this to be the difficult chapter and it turned out to be the easy one.

// the bill

It costs about one and a half per cent of what the election already costs.

Cost per voter on the roll, per five-year cycle. India spent an estimated Rs 1.35 lakh crore contesting the 2024 general election - roughly Rs 1,400 for every one of its 96.9 crore voters.



WHERE THE Rs 2,205 CRORE GOES, PER FIVE-YEAR CYCLE

Commission standing cost - item banks, security, psychometric R&D	Rs 2,000 cr
Publication, audit, appeals and the grievance tribunal	Rs 150 cr
Tier 1 test delivery, about 100,000 candidates	Rs 35 cr
Psychometric battery and interview boards, about 5,000 candidates	Rs 13 cr
Tier 2 portfolio papers, about 12,000 papers	Rs 7 cr

Election figure: Centre for Media Studies estimate for the 2024 general election, covering all direct and indirect spending by parties, candidates, government and the Election Commission. The exam-system costing is entirely my own, built bottom-up from UPSC-scale per-candidate delivery costs, and I have rounded every line up.

Cost per voter on the roll, per five-year cycle. The exam-system costing is mine, built bottom-up, and rounded up at every line.

Assume 100,000 people sit the Common Governance Aptitude Test in a cycle. That is twelve times the number of candidates who actually contested the 2024 Lok Sabha, which is the right kind of over-estimate because an open exam attracts people who then decide not to stand. At UPSC-scale delivery costs of around Rs 3,500 a head, that is Rs 35 crore.

Assume 12,000 portfolio papers are sat, at Rs 6,000 each, giving Rs 7 crore. Assume 5,000 candidates go through the full psychometric battery and boards - by far the

most expensive item per head, at Rs 25,000 - giving Rs 13 crore. Add Rs 150 crore for publication, audit, appeals and a grievance tribunal.

The real cost is the standing one: item banks that have to be continuously rewritten because they leak, security, psychometric validation and revalidation, and a professional staff good enough to resist capture. Call it Rs 400 crore a year, which is generous, and Rs 2,000 crore over a cycle.

Total: about Rs 2,205 crore per five-year cycle. Against an election that already costs Rs 1.35 lakh crore. That is 1.6 per cent. Per voter, it is about twenty-three rupees against fourteen hundred.

We are willing to spend fourteen hundred rupees a voter on the act of choosing, and we currently spend nothing at all on knowing what we are choosing between.

14

// the sequence

Ten years

The version of this proposal that starts by barring people from the ballot deserves to fail, and would. Here is the order I would actually do it in.

// the transition

Ten years, and the ballot is the last thing you touch.

Any version of this that starts by barring people from the ballot deserves to fail, and would.

●	YEAR 0 Legislate	Constitutional amendment under Art. 84(c) and a new Act. The Assessment Commission is constituted with judicial-style tenure protection.
●	YEARS 1-2 Build and validate	Item banks written and security-audited. Psychometric instruments validated on a sample of at least 10,000 serving officials and candidates. Norms published.
●	YEAR 3 Voluntary cycle	Anyone may sit. Scores are published. Nobody is barred from anything. This is the honest test of whether voters care.
●	YEARS 4-5 Bind the appointment	Passing the relevant portfolio paper becomes a condition of being APPOINTED to that ministry - and still not a condition of standing for election.
●	YEARS 6-10 Extend and review	Tier 1 required for candidature at state and then national level, with a mandatory sunset review in year 10 and a supermajority needed to renew.

The ballot is the last thing you touch, not the first.

Year 0 - legislate

A constitutional amendment binding the Article 75(5) ministerial appointment route, and an Act under Article 84(c) and Article 173(c). The Commission is constituted with the tenure protections described in Chapter 12. Nothing is required of anybody yet.

Years 1 to 2 - build and validate

Item banks written, security-audited and pilot-tested. The psychometric instruments validated on a sample of at least 10,000 serving officials, ex-candidates and volunteers, with the norms and the validity coefficients published in full. If the validity coefficients come back weak, the programme is amended in public rather than

shipped anyway. This is the phase where the whole thing should be allowed to fail honestly.

Year 3 - the voluntary cycle

Anyone may sit any paper. Scores are published. Nobody is barred from anything at all. This is the honest test of the central premise of this report, which is that **voters would use this information if they had it**. If candidates who sit the papers gain no electoral advantage whatsoever, and candidates who refuse suffer no penalty, then I am wrong about the electorate and the project should stop here. I think that is unlikely, but I want the experiment run before the coercion starts.

Years 4 to 5 - bind the appointment, not the ballot

Passing the relevant portfolio paper becomes a condition of being **appointed** to that ministry. Still not a condition of standing for election, still not a condition of sitting in the legislature, still not a condition of voting in it. This is the highest-value, lowest-risk step in the entire sequence, because it attaches the requirement to executive office rather than to representation - and it needs no argument about disenfranchisement at all.

Years 6 to 10 - extend, then review

Gate 2's floor becomes a candidacy requirement at state level, then national. And a hard sunset: in year ten, the entire Act lapses unless renewed by a two-thirds majority of both Houses on a recorded vote, with the Commission's disparate-impact report on the table. If it has become an instrument of exclusion, that is when it dies.

15

// the failure modes

Six ways this goes wrong

I have thought about these more than about the proposal itself.

1. The coaching industry eats it

Within two years of the first cycle there is a Rs 5,000 crore industry in Delhi and Hyderabad selling CGAT preparation, and it works, and the exam stops measuring capability and starts measuring who could afford eighteen months of coaching. This is exactly what happened to the UPSC exam it is modelled on.

Mitigation: heavy weighting on situational judgement and written scenario papers, which coach poorly. Rotating item banks. Free state-funded preparation material of genuinely equal quality, and free coaching for candidates below an income threshold. It helps. It does not solve it, and I want to be honest that it does not.

2. It becomes a class filter with extra steps

This is the serious one, and it is the subject of Chapter 16. Every examination filter in history has correlated with parental education and household income. The risk is that a proposal aimed at removing a wealth-and-muscle oligarchy replaces it with a credentialed one, which is not obviously an improvement and may be worse because it is better at justifying itself.

3. Papers leak

India has a recent and appalling record on examination security - NEET, teacher recruitment, state public service exams. An exam that determines who may govern is a target of a completely different order. A single confirmed leak would destroy the legitimacy of the whole apparatus permanently.

Mitigation: computer-adaptive delivery from a bank of tens of thousands of items so there is no single paper to steal, on-demand testing windows so there is no single date, and criminal liability with mandatory minimums for anybody in the chain. I still think this is the most likely proximate cause of failure.

4. Capture of the Commission

The Commission sets the papers. Whoever controls the Commission controls, at the margin, who can qualify to run which ministry. The appointment structure in Chapter 12 is designed against this and appointment structures have been designed against this before, in India, and have been defeated by the simple expedient of leaving posts vacant.

Mitigation: automatic devolution of the Commission's functions to a panel of sitting High Court judges if a vacancy persists beyond ninety days. Make the vacancy strategy useless.

5. Credentialism replaces judgement

The exam measures what an exam can measure. It cannot measure courage, or the ability to build a coalition, or the willingness to lose an election over something that matters. Some of the best politicians in Indian history would have scored badly, and some of the worst would have scored well. A system that treats the mark as the answer rather than as one input has misunderstood itself.

Mitigation: this is what Gate 5 is for. The voter is never bound by the score. But I notice that this mitigation only works if voters actually exercise independent judgement, and if they did that reliably we would not be in the current situation, so I am aware this argument has a circularity in it.

6. It gets amended into something else

The first Act is careful. The fourth amendment to it adds "and such other criteria of suitability as may be prescribed". That is how it always happens. Gate 4 acquires teeth. The floor rises from 40 per cent to 65 per cent, then to a percentile. The Iran chart at the end of Chapter 11 is not a story about Iranians; it is a story about what vetting bodies do over thirty years.

Mitigation: the sunset clause, entrenchment of the "publication only" restriction on Gate 4 as a basic-structure-adjacent provision, and the disparate-impact report as a permanent public tripwire. None of these are guarantees. Nothing is a guarantee against a determined majority.

16

// the other side

The strongest case against me

I have tried to write this chapter as if I believed it, because I think a version of me does.

1. You have described a mechanism for excluding the poor and called it merit

This is the objection that lands hardest and I do not have a complete answer to it.

Examination performance in India tracks parental education, household income, medium of instruction and urban residence with brutal consistency. A candidacy exam would not select for governing capability; it would select for having had the childhood that produces exam performance. The current Lok Sabha is 93 per cent crorepati. My reform would produce a Lok Sabha that is 93 per cent crorepati **and** credentialed, and would supply it with a legitimating story it currently lacks. Right now the wealth of Parliament is an embarrassment. Under my system it would be a qualification.

And note who gets excluded first. The Dalit sarpanch who has run a village for fifteen years and reads slowly. The tribal leader whose first language has no written examination. The woman who left school at fourteen and organised a district. Rajbala's real-world effect in Haryana was to disqualify a large share of exactly those people - the estimates run to more than half of eligible women in some categories. That is not a hypothetical harm. That is the recorded consequence of the precedent I am relying on.

2. Democracy is not a competence mechanism and you have confused two things

The point of a vote is not to identify the person most likely to make good decisions. It is to give people a non-violent way to remove rulers, and to make rulers dependent on the ruled. Competence is desirable. Consent is the actual product.

On this view my proposal makes a category error throughout. It treats representation as a job to be staffed rather than a relationship to be constituted. The MP's function is not to know things - the state employs a million people to know things - it is to be the person whose continuation in office depends on a constituency's approval. Insert a

filter between the constituency and its choice and you have degraded the only thing the institution was for, in exchange for a marginal improvement in a function it was never primarily performing.

3. Your own evidence undercuts you

I built Chapter 5 on the collapse of legislative scrutiny. But the members of the 17th Lok Sabha were not, in the main, incapable of reading a bill. Many are lawyers, doctors, engineers and career administrators. They did not fail to scrutinise legislation because they lacked the capacity. They failed because the whip system, the anti-defection law and the concentration of power in the party leadership made scrutiny pointless and career-ending.

If that is right - and I think it is substantially right - then my entire diagnosis is misattributed. The binding constraint is not member capability. It is that the Tenth Schedule turned members into voting units. An exam does nothing about that. Repealing anti-defection for non-confidence votes would do more for Indian legislative quality than every paper in Chapter 10 put together, and it would cost nothing.

4. The tested state has been tried and it produced this

India already has one of the most examined administrative cadres in the world. It selects with extraordinary rigour. And that cadre presided over the same corruption, the same delivery failures and the same capture that I am blaming on untested politicians. Singapore is the example everybody reaches for, and Singapore is a city-state of six million with an unbroken single-party government - it is not evidence about India, it is evidence about Singapore. China's cadre system is the largest political meritocracy ever constructed, and the most consistent finding about it is that promotion tracks political loyalty more reliably than performance, and that corruption remained endemic throughout.

The historical record on selecting rulers by examination is not a record of success. It is mostly a record of examination systems being captured by whoever already held power, and then providing them with a meritocratic justification.

5. Voters already have this information and do not use it

Every candidate's criminal cases and declared assets are on a public affidavit. ADR publishes it, in English and in regional languages, in searchable form, before every election. It is covered in every newspaper.

And the candidates with criminal cases win three and a half times as often.

That is not an information problem. That is voters telling us, clearly and repeatedly, that they are weighing something I have not accounted for - local protection, caste representation, access, the plausible belief that a candidate who can break rules can break them on your behalf. Adding an exam score to an affidavit that is already ignored is a solution to a problem that the data says does not exist.

6. The failure mode is not gradual

My transition plan assumes ten years of good faith. It will not get ten years of good faith. It will get one Parliament with a large majority deciding that the floor should be higher, or that "moral turpitude" belongs in Gate 1, or that Gate 4 should have teeth after all. Every safeguard in Chapter 12 can be amended by the body it is meant to constrain. A sunset clause is repealed by the same majority that would abuse the Act.

Given the choice between an unqualified legislature and a qualified one selected by a body the government controls, I would take the unqualified one, and it is not close.

Where those objections leave me

Objections 1, 3 and 6 I think are largely correct. Objection 5 is the most empirically grounded and I find it the most uncomfortable. Objections 2 and 4 I think are strong but answerable - 2 because consent and competence are not actually in tension when the filter is a floor rather than a ranking, and 4 because "the bureaucracy is also corrupt" is an argument for testing more things, not fewer.

What survives contact with all six is considerably narrower than what I started with. It is Chapter 14's Years 4 to 5, and not much else.

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// the landing

Where I actually come out

So here is what I still believe after arguing with myself for the length of this document.

The strong version - an examination floor as a condition of standing for election - I no longer think should be attempted first, and possibly not at all. Objection 1 is real, objection 6 is real, and the combination is a machine for producing a credentialed oligarchy with better public relations than the one we have. I wanted this to survive and it did not survive cleanly.

The weak version I believe in completely, and I think it is available almost immediately.

- **Bind the appointment, not the ballot.** Nobody has a right to be Finance Minister. Requiring a demonstrated pass in public finance before you can be handed the Union budget is not a restriction on democracy - it is an ordinary condition of executive office, of the sort that applies to every other job in the state, and it requires no argument about disenfranchisement whatsoever.
- **Publish everything, bar nobody.** Run the papers voluntarily. Publish the marks. Publish the refusals to sit. Let the electorate price it. This costs almost nothing, risks almost nothing, and generates the evidence needed to know whether the strong version is worth arguing about.
- **Do the Law Commission's 244th Report first.** Disqualification on framing of charges for serious offences, with day-to-day trials completed in a year. It has been sitting there since 2014. It requires no new philosophy and no new institution, and on the evidence in Chapter 2 it would do more immediate good than everything else in this report.
- **And fix the whip.** If objection 3 is right, and I think it mostly is, then the highest-return reform in Indian politics is narrowing the anti-defection law so that a member can vote against their party on an ordinary bill without losing their seat. That single change would do more for legislative quality than any examination.

I set out to argue that India should test the people who want power. I finish believing something narrower and, I think, better: that India should test the people who get it, publish the results for everyone who wants it, and stop pretending the two are the same question.

The thing I have not moved on at all is the observation I started with. A country that makes a million people compete for a thousand administrative posts, and asks nothing whatsoever of the person those posts report to, has not made a considered decision about the relationship between competence and consent. It has just never looked at the two facts side by side.

That much I am certain about. The rest of this document is an argument, and arguments are supposed to be attackable. Come at it.

Sources

Everything cited in this report, in the order it appears. Where a number is my own estimate rather than a published figure, I have said so in the text and repeated it here.

The data

- **Association for Democratic Reforms**, analysis of criminal, financial, educational and gender background of winning candidates, Lok Sabha 2024. Source of: 46 per cent of MPs with declared criminal cases (251 of 543); 31 per cent with serious cases (170); 93 per cent crorepati; average declared assets Rs 46.34 crore; 5 per cent above Rs 100 crore; 15.3 per cent versus 4.4 per cent win rates; the 55 per cent rise in MPs with criminal cases since 2009.
- **Association for Democratic Reforms**, asset comparison of re-contesting and re-elected MPs. Source of: 324 re-contesting MPs, average assets Rs 21.55 crore in 2019 to Rs 30.88 crore in 2024, a rise of Rs 9.33 crore or 43 per cent; 102 re-elected MPs, 110 per cent asset growth 2014 to 2024. State-level figures for MLAs 2017 to 2022 (56 per cent) and Arunachal Pradesh (919 per cent) from the corresponding ADR state analyses.
- **ADR trend series** for MPs with declared criminal cases: 2004 (24 per cent), 2009 (30 per cent), 2014 (34 per cent), 2019 (43 per cent), 2024 (46 per cent); serious cases 2009 (14), 2014 (21), 2019 (29), 2024 (31 per cent).
- **PRS Legislative Research**, Functioning of the 17th Lok Sabha. Source of: 16 per cent of bills referred to committee; 35 per cent passed with under an hour of discussion; 58 per cent passed within two weeks; 274 sitting days across five years; 55 average annual sitting days against 135 in the first Lok Sabha.
- **Election Commission of India**, General Elections 2024. Source of: 96.88 crore electors, 64.2 crore votes cast, 65.79 per cent turnout, 543 constituencies, seven phases, 19 April to 1 June 2024.
- **Centre for Media Studies**, estimate of 2024 general election expenditure at approximately Rs 1.35 lakh crore, all direct and indirect spending, and the resulting figure of roughly Rs 1,400 per elector.

- **Ministry of Finance**, reply to Lok Sabha, February 2024: electoral bonds worth Rs 16,518 crore sold in thirty tranches.
- **Salary, Allowances and Pension of Members of Parliament Act, 1954**, as revised with effect from 1 April 2023 and notified in 2025: Rs 1.24 lakh salary, Rs 87,000 constituency allowance, Rs 75,000 office expense allowance, Rs 2,500 daily allowance, Rs 31,000 pension.
- **Transparency International**, Corruption Perceptions Index 2025, released February 2026: India ranked 91st of 182 with a score of 39, against a global average of 42, up from 96th in the previous year.
- **Guardian Council vetting outcomes, Iran**: 2024 Majlis, approximately 15,200 of roughly 37,000 registrants approved; 2024 Assembly of Experts, 138 of 510; 2016 Assembly of Experts, approximately 80 per cent rejected.

The law

- **Constitution of India**, Articles 84, 102, 173, 75(5), 164(4), 19(1)(a), and the Tenth Schedule.
- **Representation of the People Act, 1951**, sections 8, 33 and 34.
- **Rajbala v. State of Haryana**, (2016) 2 SCC 445, decided 10 December 2015. Educational and other qualifications for panchayat candidature upheld; the right to contest held to be a statutory and not a fundamental right.
- **Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India**, decided 15 February 2024. Electoral Bond Scheme struck down as violative of Article 19(1)(a).
- **Law Commission of India, 244th Report on Electoral Disqualifications**, Justice A. P. Shah, February 2014. Recommended disqualification on framing of charges, operative until acquittal or six years, with day-to-day trial completed within a year.
- **Justice K. S. Puttaswamy v. Union of India**, (2017) 10 SCC 1, for the proportionality test referenced in the Electronics and IT paper.

The comparative material

- **Daniel A. Bell**, *The China Model: Political Meritocracy and the Limits of Democracy*, Princeton University Press, 2015, together with the substantial critical literature on it - in particular the finding that promotion in the Chinese cadre system tracks political loyalty more reliably than measured performance.
- **Services Selection Board** assessment methodology: fifteen Officer Like Qualities across four factors, assessed over five days through projective techniques, group testing and a personal interview by three independent assessors.

— **Union Public Service Commission** annual reports for applicant, appearance and selection figures. Applicant and vacancy numbers vary substantially year to year; the figures used are round approximations for scale.

My own numbers

Every figure in Chapter 13 is my own estimate, built bottom-up. So are all the module weightings in Chapter 10, every syllabus, every signature question, the floors and pass marks throughout, the Commission's structure, and the ten-year sequence. They are arguments, not findings. Argue with them.

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// colophon

How this thing was made

Since the whole report is about publishing your working, it would be odd not to publish this bit.

The palette

The colour system is built for this subject specifically rather than pulled off a shelf.

- **Ballot-ink violet.** The anchor colour is the violet of silver nitrate - the indelible ink on the left index finger, which is the one universally recognised object in Indian democracy and the only credential currently required to participate in it. It carries every chapter number, every heading and the spine of the document.
- **Ashoka brass.** Violet's complement on the traditional wheel is yellow; a warm brass sits just off it, at a split-complement. That is why gold on purple reads as institutional across almost every culture that has ever had a parliament, and it is exactly the register this subject sits in. Brass carries rules, numerals and emphasis, and never body text - at 3.6:1 against the paper it clears the large-text contrast threshold and not the small-text one.
- **Vermilion and exam-teal,** at roughly 6 degrees and 180 degrees, are a true complementary pair - the maximum separation available. This is deliberate and structural: everything diagnosing the problem is red, everything proposing a fix is teal. You should be able to tell which half of the argument a page belongs to from across a room, before reading a word.
- **Warm paper** rather than white, which drops body-text contrast from about 21:1 to about 17:1. Still far above the accessibility floor, and considerably kinder over sixty pages.
- **One imported element.** The highlighter yellow is lifted unchanged from my website. It is the only thing in here that is not chosen for this subject, and it is the tell that this came from the same desk as everything else.

The type

Display faces are set heavy and geometric; body copy is a serif because forty pages of sans-serif is a punishment; kickers, data and captions are monospaced, which is the

one typographic habit I have carried over wholesale from my site because I like what the double slash does to a line.

The charts

Twelve figures, all drawn to the same house rules: a monospaced kicker, a brass rule, a display headline that states the finding rather than describing the axes, a grey subtitle carrying the method, and a monospaced source line at the foot that names the origin of every number and admits which ones are mine.